The Negro Speaks of Rivers

Langston Hughes · published in The Crisis · June 1921 · poem in full

Source: The Crisis (NAACP magazine), Vol. 22, No. 2; Library of Congress, Langston Hughes Papers.

Langston Hughes was 17, on a train across the Mississippi at sunset, when he wrote this poem on the back of an envelope. It became the signature opening of his career and a founding poem of the Harlem Renaissance — the explosion of Black literary, musical, and visual culture in 1920s New York. The poem connects Black American experience to a deep, continent-spanning history of African civilization, rejecting the era's racist assumption that Black history began with slavery.

Connect: Hughes reclaims African history in his poem. Compare his cultural project to Frederick Douglass's writings (Class 14) — both are Black writers using words to redefine Black identity in America.

Key Passages

The poem, in full

I've known rivers: I've known rivers ancient as the world and older than the flow of human blood in human veins. My soul has grown deep like the rivers. I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young. I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep. I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it. I heard the singing of the Mississippi when Abe Lincoln went down to New Orleans, and I've seen its muddy bosom turn all golden in the sunset. I've known rivers: ancient, dusky rivers. My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. HIPP — Purpose (1920s media): What is Hughes trying to do by publishing this poem in The Crisis specifically?

2. How does the poem rewrite the geography of 'Black history'?

3. Connect this poem to ONE other Harlem Renaissance work (Hurston, Locke, Armstrong, Ellington, etc.).